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Title: The Final Sprint

A. Situation or Experience

This Pre-Finals period became incredibly demanding as a fourth-year IT student serving as the System Analyst for our capstone team. With our final system defense scheduled for November 20, my primary responsibilities involved finalizing the Software Requirements Specification, updating the UML diagrams to reflect the latest code changes, and ensuring the overall system architecture aligned with our users' needs. At the same time, I had to prepare for a comprehensive networking mock exam and cover extra shifts at my part-time IT support job. Juggling the strict documentation deadlines for the defense with my other academic and work obligations created a highly compressed timeline with very little room for error.

B. Emotional and Cognitive Response

My initial reaction to this situation was a heavy sense of pressure and mental fatigue. I felt like a bottleneck in a server, constantly receiving too many requests and failing to process them efficiently. Cognitively, I experienced a noticeable lack of focus. Every time I opened our documentation to refine the system flowcharts, my mind would immediately drift to the networking exam material. Conversely, when I tried to study, I kept worrying about missing critical requirements in our defense documentation. My thoughts were dominated by concerns about our group receiving a low grade because of a flawed architecture diagram, or not doing well on my exam. This constant mental switching made it difficult to concentrate and left me staring blankly at my monitors without making much progress.

C. SEL Insight

This Pre-Finals period tested my **Self-management** and **Responsible decision-making**, prompting me to prioritize tasks based on the November 20 defense deadline. I applied **Responsible decision-making** by delegating quality assurance checks to my development team, allowing me to prepare for my networking exam. Using **Self-management**, I time-boxed my schedule to finalize the System Requirements Specification without distractions, ensuring our documentation was ready.